

Pongo pygmaeus

Bornean orangutan



Height 28–38 in
(72–97 cm)
Weight 66–185 lb
(30–85 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Critically
endangered

Location S.E. Asia (Borneo)



The orangutan is very much a tree-dwelling animal, feeding, sleeping, and breeding in the forest canopy, with only males occasionally coming to ground. It spends most of the day looking for and eating fruit and other food, and at night it builds a sleeping platform by weaving branches together. The female gives birth in a treetop nest, and the tiny infant clings to its mother as she clambers about the canopy. The pair will stay together until the youngster is about 8 years old. Orangutans live in widely scattered communities—probably determined by the availability of food. They are mainly solitary, but may meet up with others at fruit trees, and adolescent females may travel together for 2 or 3 days. All will be aware of neighboring males from their roaring “long-calls.” Until fairly recently, orangutans were considered to be a single species—*Pongo pygmaeus*. Genetic research has now led to two distinct species being recognized:

CONSERVATION

Although protected by law, infants are still captured and sold illegally as pets. Palm oil plantations are also a major threat to their habitat. Their survival is important as they are a keystone species, vital to dispersing fruit seeds. Projects to rehabilitate rescued orangutans have a good success rate, but some animals find it difficult to readjust to life in their diminishing natural habitat.



the Bornean and the Sumatran (*Pongo abelii*). Loss of habitat presents the main threat to both species as their forest homelands are destroyed by logging and fire. It is estimated that Bornean orangutans now number, 45,000–69,000, while as few as 7,300 Sumatran orangutans survive.

“PERSON OF THE FOREST”

The male orangutan—which means “person of the forest” in Malay—looks strikingly different from the female, with large cheek pads (which grow bigger as the animals age), a long beard and mustache, and a hanging throat pouch. He also has long arm hair, which hangs like a cape when the arms are outstretched.



ARBOREAL APE
With its long arms, spanning up to 7¼ ft (2.2 m), and feet that can grasp branches like hands, this male orangutan is well adapted to life in the treetops. Its limbs are also extremely flexible, with wrist, hip, and shoulder joints allowing a greater range of movement than in the other great apes.

FOOD FROM THE FOREST

Fruit is the favourite food of orangutans, but they will also eat other parts of plants, as well as honey, small animals such as lizards, termites and nestling birds, and eggs.

FAMILY GROUP

A mother and her offspring forage together in the forest, plucking fruit and leaves from the trees.



EATING HABITS

Orangutans use their hands and teeth to prepare their food, stripping plants and peeling fruit to expose the succulent flesh.

